

# The side nav that took nine seconds

A project collaboration product, about two years old. Roughly four thousand paying workspaces.

## WHAT HAPPENED

The left-hand navigation lists your projects. Each row shows the project name, how many collaborators it has, and how many tasks are in it. It is the first thing anybody sees after logging in.

It was written in an afternoon, by a developer working against his own workspace: **three projects, five tasks between them**. It felt instant. Code review passed. It shipped, and for eighteen months nobody said anything about it.

Last Tuesday your largest customer — an agency, forty active projects, a couple of hundred tasks in each — opened a ticket saying the application **“hangs on load.”** They have been living with it for a while, they say. They assumed it was their network.

The engineer who wrote the side nav left the company in March.

## WHAT YOU HAVE BEEN TOLD

- The customer says the page takes **roughly nine seconds**. They are not exaggerating; they sent a screen recording.
- **Support cannot reproduce it.** On their test account the page loads immediately.
- The database team has looked. They report **no slow queries** — nothing in the slow query log, nothing above 50 ms.
- Database CPU is at 30%. Memory is fine. No alerts fired.
- Nothing was deployed last week. Nobody changed anything.
- The account is up for renewal in five weeks.

## YOUR FIRST HOUR

- 1 Where do you look first, and why there?**  

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- 2 The database team says there are no slow queries. Are they wrong?**  

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- 3 Support cannot reproduce it. What is different about their account?**  

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- 4 What would you ask the customer to send you?**  

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- 5 You are on the call in one hour. What do you say?**  

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